what little of the chieftains' confiscated wealth remained with him. The water carrier produced two hundred silver coins, a silver bracelet and a pod of musk. The money and bracelet Humayun returned to their owners; the pod of musk he broke upon a china plate. As the plate was passed around the tent, Humayun gave a short but moving speech, telling the gathered chiefs, 'This is all the present I can afford to make you on the birth of my son.' Yet, he hoped, his son's fame would one day fill the world 'as the perfume of the musk now fills this apartment'.

Drums and trumpets completed the short ceremony. There wasn't time for more; the camp had to resume its march.

All that Abul Fazl writes, meanwhile, of '[m]elodious musicians and enchanting vocalists', harps, lutes, rebecs and tambourines filling the camp air may be safely ignored, but the historian, giddy with joy, offers one little anecdote that rings with truth. When Humayun saw his son's horoscope, the new father locked himself in his 'private chamber' and here, alone and able to rejoice at ease, 'he fell a'dancing'.

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Back in Umarkot, meanwhile, Akbar had had his first bath. Afterwards, wrapped in a soft blanket, he formed the first alliances of his long political career: the bond by milk with his wet nurses or foster mothers, his *anaka*s. The first of ten to hold him was Jiji Anaka, wife of Shamsuddin of Ghazni who had rescued Humayun from the riverbank in Kannauj.[56] Akbar was smiling – another small miracle in an infant – causing hearts to 'rejoice' as the women fed him, then put him in a cradle of sandalwood and aloe, rocking him gently and singing him a lullaby made with the names of God.

Many of these women and their families would play critical roles in the life and reign of the baby they suckled now. For the moment, however, no one – not even Maulana Chand – could have predicted the course of their linked destinies. For the moment, the world turned very much as usual, as the newborn Niru'un took his first, small breaths of its air.

. Unless otherwise specified, all quotations from the *Akbarnama* are from the translation by Henry Beveridge. Abu'l Fazl, *The Akbarnama of Abu'l Fazl* (completed by Inayatullah), trans. Henry Beveridge, vols 1, 2 and 3 (first published 1902–1939; Low Price Publications, 2017).

. Occasionally, as here, I have quoted from a more recent translation of the *Akbarnama* by W.M. Thackston: Abu'l Fazl. *The History of Akbar*, trans. W.M. Thackston, vols 1–6 (Murty Classical Library of India, Harvard University Press, 2015, 2016, 2017, 2018, 2019, 2020). This phrase